Crafty

By Paul Rudnick

Barbara Ellen Diggs stands in a conference room of a municipal building in Decatur, Illinois. Barbara Ellen is a sweet-faced, extremely good-natured, outgoing woman, wearing a sweatshirt with a floral applique or a hand knit sweater. She is surrounded by tables holding many homemade craft items.

INTRODUCTION

This selection is all about your relationship with your mother, so take a moment to picture her in your mind. What are her hobbies, dreams, feelings? Do you even know? I admit - I'm guilty – Before I worked on this selection, I knew none of these things about my mom. So often we take our mothers for granted. We don't see them as "real" people – we just see the tiny portion that fits into our lives – Breakfast, dinner, money, someone to listen to what's going on in OUR lives. We are embarrassed by them, we downplay their importance and we question their intelligence.

But in Crafty by Paul Rudnick . . . we are introduced to Barbara Ellen Diggs, mother to Hank . . . and we find out that she is real – funny and embarrassing sometimes – but so real. Listen carefully to her and then go home and listen to your mom. But more importantly . . . hear her!

BARBARA: Hi. I'm Barbara Ellen Diggs, and I'm a craftsperson here in Decatur. And this morning I would like to speak to you on the critical importance of crafts in our culture. Before I discovered crafts, I suffered from clinical depression and had no self-esteem; but today I exhibit my work statewide and I teach workshops at our local women's prison, where a lady who slaughtered her entire family now makes notecards personalized with sequins and dried corn. I have invented over five hundred and twelve different saleables for Christmas bazaars, including doorknob covers, *(She holds up a board holding three doorknobs with crocheted holiday covers.)* microwave bonnets *(She holds up a large quilted microwave bonnet)* and toilet paper caddies *(She holds up a crocheted cover for a roll of toilet paper.)* And I have recently hand-crocheted a tuxedo for my toaster. *(She holds up a toaster dressed in a hand crocheted black and white cover with a bowtie.)* For wardrobe items I practice applique, which is the art of heat-bonding a felt Santa or a three-dimensional chenille snowman onto a garment. *(She holds up a sweatshirt appliqued with a snowman and a Santa.)* Last Christmas, across a particularly memorable sweatshirt, I created an entire colonial

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village, including an ice-skating pond, a blacksmith's shop, and a mischievous Jewish peddler. I also deeply enjoy scrap booking. *(She picks up a scrapbook and opens it to a page, showing it to the audience as she points to various features.)* For example, on this page, I color-xeroxed a simple Polaroid of my Aunt Polly, and I placed the image at the center of a piece of oaktag. Then I surrounded the picture with heart-shaped lace doilies, crepe-paper rosettes, and silk ribbon worked to spell out "Aunt Polly." I've also included some ticket stubs from a movie we saw together, *That Darn Cat,* the invitation to her wedding to Uncle Walt, and a tiny burlap bag containing one of her kidney stones. The page now weighs over fifteen pounds, and it can tell you Aunt Polly's entire life story . . . . and I don't even like her.

Some sophisticated people say that crafts aren't art, but by the same token, some people say that New Yorkers aren't people. Crafts allow me to express myself, to create something worth dusting. When I pick up a crochet hook or a staple gun I'm tingling. I'm transported. This one time I started rubber cementing sea shells onto a keepsake box as a baby gift, and by the time I looked up, that child was in college.

My family has always been very supportive of my hobbies, well, except for my son, whom I loved dearly. Hank was always - very special. He always used to scold me for using words like that, what did he call them - euphemisms. He said, Mom, I'm gay. And I said, no you're not, you're special. And he said no, that makes me sound like I'm retarded. And I would say, I wish. And we would laugh. It never really bothered me, even though he did move away and started working for a fancy Broadway costume designer in New York and he didn't come back home all that often. But we would write back and forth, and he would send me trims and braid, all these beautiful expensive things from the costumes and I wouldn't know what to do with them. But to thank him I would send him Hummel figurines, you know, those cute little ceramic children, holding umbrellas or petting kittens, or sitting on a swing. And he'd get so angry on the phone, he'd say Mom, don't send me anything you can order from TV . . . which upset me, so to express that, I sent him the Hummel sad little clown. And he said that Hummels were originally made by Nazis, and I said they were not, they were made by German nuns who didn't read the newspaper. I just liked the picture of all those Hummels, all lined up in his New York studio apartment, to remind him of where he came from. I'd say Hank, maybe you're still wearing white T-shirts and Levi's, but I remember when you didn't shrink them. I told

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him, if homosexuality is genetic, then maybe so is home shopping.

And then, well, he got sick. With that terrible disease. And I flew to New York to see him in the hospital, and do you know what I brought? Nothing. I didn't want to embarrass him, in front of his friends. Who were all so sweet, I mean, they all sort of sounded alike and they all kept kissing and hugging me and saying, Henry, we love your Mom, she's a hoot. A hoot. That means I wear polyester without irony. But they were all really very nice, and so good to Hank, and when we were finally alone he looked up at me and said, so what did you bring me? A potholder, a picture frame decorated with twine and plastic daisies, two little bunnies on a sled? And I said no, I know all of that just upsets you, makes you feel like a hick. And he leaned back onto the pillow and he said, oh. It's okay. I just wanted to see you.

And I stayed there until, well, let's use one of those euphemisms, until he passed on. Maybe that's why euphemisms get invented, not because people are ashamed, but because - they hate the real word too much. And I hated that word, and I hated that disease, and for the longest time I just went to work and came home and I didn't touch a thing. Not a needle, not a bobbin, not a hole punch or a pair of pinking shears. I would not bring color or beauty or rickrack into this world. I was just too sad.

And then one day I saw on the television, that quilt. All spread out in Washington, right on the ground in front of the Capitol. Over seventy-two thousand squares, each for a different man, woman, or child. And I looked at it and I thought, my Lord, it's like a cemetery created by the *Ladies Home Journal.* And I took all the fancy trims and laces and bugle beads that Hank had sent me, and I went over to Newberry's and I got a rectangle of hot pink felt. And I made his name in embroidered script, and I stitched on one of his report cards and his mittens and one of his T-shirts which said, "No One Knows I'm Gay." Only I changed it so it said, "No One Knows I'm From Decatur." And in the corner I attached one of those labels I always use, that says, "Especially Handmade Just For You By Barbara Ellen Diggs." And I folded up the whole thing and sent it away, so Lord knows where it is now.

But that was ages ago, and now they have all that new medicine, so people, well, at least some people, can keep going. And we've got whole new ways to hurt people, like that 9/11. And I have to tell you something, and you're going to think I'm awful, but when I first heard about it,

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on TV, and they said Muslim terrorists had attacked those buildings? I swear to God, I thought they said muslin. Muslin terrorists. And I didn't understand and I thought, they're just using cheap cotton? But of course then I found out what it really was, and I saw that all of those people had died and I wondered, will there be a quilt? And I thought, well, probably not in New York, where everyone is so fancy, I thought, maybe they'll make a duvet. I'm sorry.

And about a year or so later, I went back to New York, because I was a finalist in a cake-decorating competition. It was cutthroat. The woman next to me, from Ohio, she was so sure that she was going to win, because she'd baked a five-layer devil's food supreme, frosted with the entire Battle of Gettysburg. She'd used mocha pudding and shredded coconut for the battlefield, and the Union forces were Necco wafers, and the Confederates were all Gummi Bears. But the judges said it was contrived. No comment.

And I thought that maybe I had a shot, for my special Easter Sunday extravaganza. I had frosted a lemon meringue sheet cake with an exact replica of Leonardo DaVinci's "The Last Supper," only instead of the apostles everyone at the table was either a chocolate bunny or a marshmallow peep. But then that Gettysburg woman made a stink, and said that my work was sacrilegious, because I'd included Mary Magdalene, but I said, I know that it's controversial, but she's a peanut M&M!

So I lost, and the city reminded me of Hank, and people said that you could sometimes still smell the, what was it, the jet fuel from that day. And I just couldn't go downtown because it was so terrible, and because that's where Hank lived and so I walked over, from the Marriot, to Central Park. And they were having this, I didn't really know what to call it, but people said it was an installation. By this French artist named Christo. And it seems that this Christo person goes all around the world, and he wraps up landmarks in fabric. I'm not kidding. That's what he does, he pays for it and he gets all of these helpers and all of these sewing machines and they wrap up buildings and islands and bridges. I'm not kidding! And I wondered if maybe, when he was younger, for Christmas, if Christo once gave someone a particularly bulky item, like a bicycle or an outdoor barbeque, and he had to wrap it. Eureka! And in the park, he'd put up hundreds of these sort of archways, these aluminum gates, and from each one, from the top, there was a bright orange curtain. And I thought, well, now I know what an installation is - it's

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just a giant French crafts project.

And I stood there and the sun came out and the breeze was blowing all of those orange curtains and it didn't make any sense, but it was very pretty. And then I saw this car, this limousine, driving slowly through the park, and this woman next to me, she said that the man in the car was Christo, with his wife, Jean-Claude. And that they drove through all the time, to watch people's reactions. And as the car got closer the window rolled down and inside I could see this little man, Christo, and I waved. And he waved back, and I didn't know what to say, so I just pointed to all of the gates and I said, "Wow! Yardage!" And the car drove past and I asked the woman, I said, does this installation, and all of this orange fabric, does it make people feel better? And I could tell that she was a New Yorker because she said, *(She uses a tougher New York voice.)* "Yes, it does. Because it's free and they're gonna take it down." And I hadn't really talked about him in so long, especially not to a stranger, but I stood under one of those gates and I told her about Hank. And I asked her if she was there, if she was in the city on 9/11. And she said yes. And I asked, did you lose anyone, and she said yes. That her brother was a firefighter.

And it's strange, but when I got back to Decatur, I started to feel a little cheerier, for the first time in years. My friend Susan Deckerman says that maybe I found closure, and I said, Susan, Oprah is just a person. But I've started to make these sock monkeys *(She picks up a pair of sock monkeys from the table.)* and I take them to our local hospital and I hang them on the patient's IV stands. Because maybe when a sick person sees a sock monkey, they'll smile.

And that woman I met in New York, in the park, her name is Eileen and we've kept in touch. And after they took those gates down, Eileen got some of the fabric and sent it to me. And so I made this ... *(She holds up a bright orange, quilted oven mitt.)* It's a quilted oven mitt. And I'm gonna send it to Eileen, with a note that says, "You see? That Christo can make something useful." I don't know if I believe in God anymore. But I do believe in cute. I believe in glue. I believe in hot pink felt. And maybe if I was a New Yorker, I would believe in orange shower curtains hanging in Central Park. Amen.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
NIETOC
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